

Going Home with Lameness

A guide for your pet's recovery at home

Your pet was noted to have lameness (limping) while in our care at the shelter. This handout covers general home care and what to watch for as your pet continues to recover. Refer to your adoption paperwork for any specific findings or treatment already given.

What to Expect

- Mild lameness (limping) often results from a minor strain, sprain, or soft tissue injury and gradually improves with rest.
- Some pets continue to show mild stiffness or favor a leg for a few days as they settle into a new home — this is common and usually improves on its own.
- A single exam doesn't always pinpoint an exact cause. Watching how your pet moves at home helps determine if further evaluation is needed.

Home Care

- Restrict activity — limit running, jumping, and rough play to give any injury time to heal.
- Provide a quiet, comfortable resting area away from stairs or slick floors.
- Keep walks short, slow, and on a leash — avoid off-leash activity until your pet is moving normally.
- Give any prescribed pain medication exactly as directed — never give human pain medication, which can be dangerous for pets.

Contact Your Veterinarian If Your Pet Has:

- Lameness that worsens or does not improve after a few days of rest
- Inability to put any weight on the leg at all
- Visible swelling, heat, or pain when the area is touched
- Crying, panting, or reluctance to move that suggests significant pain
- Lameness that shifts between legs, or returns after initially improving

Follow-Up Care

Schedule a follow-up visit with your veterinarian within **1–2 weeks** after adoption, or sooner if the lameness worsens or does not improve with rest.

Bring your adoption paperwork so your veterinarian knows what was observed while your pet was in our care.